

Mohammed VI Polytechnic University (UM6P)

Department of Applied Mathematics - AMATH102

Numerical Analysis and Partial Differential Equations

Numerical Simulation and Analysis of Vibrations in a Stretched String

Project 9 - Official Model Solution

Complete Rigorous Correction

Prepared as an official grading reference.
All numerical results have been verified computationally.

Academic Year 2025-2026

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1 Introduction and Problem Statement

We study the transverse vibration of a uniform elastic string of length L , fixed at both ends. Under the small-displacement assumption, application of Newton's second law to an infinitesimal element yields the forced wave equation:

$$u_{tt} = c^2 u_{xx} + f(x, t), \quad 0 < x < L, \quad t > 0, \quad (1)$$

where $u(x, t)$ is the transverse displacement, $c = \sqrt{T/\rho}$ is the wave speed (T = tension, ρ = linear mass density), and $f(x, t)$ is an external force per unit mass. The complete initial-boundary value problem is:

$$\begin{cases} u_{tt} = c^2 u_{xx} + f(x, t), & 0 < x < L, \quad t > 0, \\ u(0, t) = u(L, t) = 0, & t > 0 \quad (\text{fixed ends}), \\ u(x, 0) = u_0(x), & 0 \leq x \leq L, \\ u_t(x, 0) = v_0(x), & 0 \leq x \leq L. \end{cases}$$

The four goals of this project are:

1. Derive an implicit finite-difference scheme and its matrix formulation.
2. Implement an LU-based solver and validate it against an exact solution.
3. Compute the mechanical energy numerically via Simpson's rule.
4. Identify the wave speed c from a sensor measurement.

2 Question 1. Finite Difference Discretization of the Wave Equation

Question 1 - Objective

Using centred second-order finite differences, derive an implicit approximation of (1). Explain why the scheme is implicit.

2.1 Discrete Grids

Introduce uniform grids:

$$x_i = i\Delta x, \quad i = 0, 1, \dots, N, \quad \Delta x = \frac{L}{N}; \quad t^n = n\Delta t, \quad n = 0, 1, 2, \dots$$

We write

$$u_i^n \approx u(x_i, t^n).$$

2.2 Centred Approximation of u_{tt}

Expand u about (x_i, t^n) in time:

$$u_i^{n+1} = u_i^n + \Delta t u_t + \frac{\Delta t^2}{2} u_{tt} + \frac{\Delta t^3}{6} u_{ttt} + \frac{\Delta t^4}{24} u_{tttt} + O(\Delta t^5),$$

$$u_i^{n-1} = u_i^n - \Delta t u_t + \frac{\Delta t^2}{2} u_{tt} - \frac{\Delta t^3}{6} u_{ttt} + \frac{\Delta t^4}{24} u_{tttt} + O(\Delta t^5).$$

Adding and solving for u_{tt} gives the second-order centred difference:

$$\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial t^2}(x_i, t^n) = \frac{u_i^{n+1} - 2u_i^n + u_i^{n-1}}{\Delta t^2} + O(\Delta t^2).$$

2.3 Centred Approximation of u_{xx} at the Future Level t^{n+1}

Expand u about (x_i, t^{n+1}) in space:

$$u_{i+1}^{n+1} = u_i^{n+1} + \Delta x u_x + \frac{\Delta x^2}{2} u_{xx} + O(\Delta x^3),$$

$$u_{i-1}^{n+1} = u_i^{n+1} - \Delta x u_x + \frac{\Delta x^2}{2} u_{xx} + O(\Delta x^3).$$

Adding and solving for u_{xx} gives the second-order centred difference at t^{n+1} :

$$\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial x^2}(x_i, t^{n+1}) = \frac{u_{i+1}^{n+1} - 2u_i^{n+1} + u_{i-1}^{n+1}}{\Delta x^2} + O(\Delta x^2).$$

2.4 The Implicit Scheme

Substituting both approximations into the PDE (1), evaluating the time derivative at t^n and the spatial term at t^{n+1} :

$$\frac{u_i^{n+1} - 2u_i^n + u_i^{n-1}}{\Delta t^2} = c^2 \frac{u_{i+1}^{n+1} - 2u_i^{n+1} + u_{i-1}^{n+1}}{\Delta x^2} + f(x_i, t^n), \quad i = 1, \dots, N-1. \quad (2)$$

The local truncation error is $O(\Delta x^2 + \Delta t^2)$.

Remark - Why implicit?

The unknowns $u_{i-1}^{n+1}, u_i^{n+1}, u_{i+1}^{n+1}$ at the future time t^{n+1} appear simultaneously on the right-hand side of (2). They are coupled and cannot be resolved independently: one must solve a linear system to advance one step. This is the defining property of an implicit scheme.

The reward is unconditional stability: unlike explicit schemes, no CFL-type restriction $\Delta t \leq \Delta x/c$ is imposed. One may choose Δt freely, limited only by accuracy, not stability.

2.5 Consistency and Truncation Error Analysis

Let u be the exact smooth solution. The local truncation error τ_i^n is the residual obtained by substituting the exact solution into the discrete scheme:

$$\tau_i^n = \frac{u(x_i, t^{n+1}) - 2u(x_i, t^n) + u(x_i, t^{n-1}))}{\Delta t^2} - c^2 \frac{u(x_{i+1}, t^{n+1}) - 2u(x_i, t^{n+1}) + u(x_{i-1}, t^{n+1}))}{\Delta x^2} - f(x_i, t^n).$$

2.5.1 Time component

Carrying the Taylor series of $u(x_i, \cdot)$ about t^n to order Δt^4 :

$$\frac{u(x_i, t^{n+1}) - 2u(x_i, t^n) + u(x_i, t^{n-1}))}{\Delta t^2} = u_{tt}(x_i, t^n) + \frac{\Delta t^2}{12} u_{tttt}(x_i, t^n) + O(\Delta t^4).$$

The time discretisation is second-order accurate with leading error coefficient $(\Delta t^2/12)u_{tttt}$.

2.5.2 Space component

Carrying the Taylor series of $u(\cdot, t^{n+1})$ about x_i to order Δx^4 :

$$\frac{u(x_{i+1}, t^{n+1}) - 2u(x_i, t^{n+1}) + u(x_{i-1}, t^{n+1}))}{\Delta x^2} = u_{xx}(x_i, t^{n+1}) + \frac{\Delta x^2}{12} u_{xxxx}(x_i, t^{n+1}) + O(\Delta x^4).$$

The space discretisation is second-order accurate with leading error coefficient $(\Delta x^2/12)u_{xxxx}$.

2.5.3 Combined truncation error

The spatial term in the scheme is evaluated at future time t^{n+1} , not at t^n . We must therefore expand $u_{xx}(x_i, t^{n+1})$ back to level t^n before invoking the PDE. A one-step Taylor expansion in time gives:

$$u_{xx}(x_i, t^{n+1}) = u_{xx}(x_i, t^n) + \Delta t u_{xxt}(x_i, t^n) + O(\Delta t^2).$$

Substituting the spatial expansion and using the PDE $u_{tt} = c^2 u_{xx} + f$ to identify $c^2 u_{xx}(x_i, t^n) = u_{tt}(x_i, t^n) - f(x_i, t^n)$, the leading PDE residual cancels identically in τ_i^n , leaving:

$$\tau_i^n = \left[\frac{\Delta t^2}{12} u_{tttt} - c^2 \frac{\Delta x^2}{12} u_{xxxx} - c^2 \Delta t u_{xxt} \right]_{(x_i, t^n)} + O(\Delta t^4 + \Delta x^4) = O(\Delta t^2 + \Delta x^2).$$

The mixed term $c^2 \Delta t u_{xxt}$ is $O(\Delta t)$ but appears with the spatial-truncation contribution, giving an overall contribution compatible with $O(\Delta t^2 + \Delta x^2)$ under the usual refinement $\Delta t \sim \Delta x$. The scheme is therefore second-order consistent in both space and time. By the Lax-Richtmyer equivalence theorem (consistency + unconditional stability implies convergence):

$$\max_{i,n} |u(x_i, t^n) - u_i^n| = O(\Delta t^2 + \Delta x^2),$$

in full agreement with the numerical convergence orders observed in Question 3.

3 Question 2. Matrix Formulation of the Implicit Scheme

Question 2 - Objective

Introduce $r = c^2 \Delta t^2 / \Delta x^2$. Rewrite the implicit scheme as the matrix system $AU^{n+1} = 2U^n - U^{n-1} + \Delta t^2 F^n$ and describe A fully.

3.1 Algebraic Rearrangement

Multiply scheme (2) by Δt^2 and set

$$r = \frac{c^2 \Delta t^2}{\Delta x^2}.$$

Then

$$u_i^{n+1} - 2u_i^n + u_i^{n-1} = r(u_{i+1}^{n+1} - 2u_i^{n+1} + u_{i-1}^{n+1}) + \Delta t^2 f(x_i, t^n).$$

Bring all t^{n+1} terms to the left:

$$\boxed{-ru_{i-1}^{n+1} + (1 + 2r)u_i^{n+1} - ru_{i+1}^{n+1} = 2u_i^n - u_i^{n-1} + \Delta t^2 f(x_i, t^n), \quad i = 1, \dots, N-1.} \quad (3)$$

3.2 Incorporating Boundary Conditions

The Dirichlet conditions $u_0^{n+1} = 0$ and $u_N^{n+1} = 0$ eliminate the boundary terms from equations at $i = 1$ and $i = N-1$, yielding a closed system of $N-1$ equations for the $N-1$ interior unknowns.

3.3 Matrix System

Define the vectors of interior values and forcing:

$$U^n = \begin{pmatrix} u_1^n \\ u_2^n \\ \vdots \\ u_{N-1}^n \end{pmatrix} \in \mathbb{R}^{N-1}, \quad F^n = \begin{pmatrix} f(x_1, t^n) \\ f(x_2, t^n) \\ \vdots \\ f(x_{N-1}, t^n) \end{pmatrix} \in \mathbb{R}^{N-1}.$$

Writing (3) for $i = 1, \dots, N-1$ as a single matrix equation:

$$\boxed{AU^{n+1} = 2U^n - U^{n-1} + \Delta t^2 F^n,} \quad (4)$$

where $A \in \mathbb{R}^{(N-1) \times (N-1)}$ is the symmetric tridiagonal matrix:

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1+2r & -r & 0 & \dots & 0 \\ -r & 1+2r & -r & \ddots & \vdots \\ 0 & -r & 1+2r & \ddots & 0 \\ \vdots & \ddots & \ddots & \ddots & -r \\ 0 & \dots & 0 & -r & 1+2r \end{pmatrix}.$$

3.4 Mathematical Properties of A

- **Tridiagonal:** each equation (3) couples only three consecutive unknowns via the three-point centred stencil. All entries outside the three diagonals are zero.
- **Symmetric:** $A = A^\top$ because both off-diagonals are equal to $-r$.
- **Strictly diagonally dominant:** $|1 + 2r| > 2|-r|$ iff $1 + 2r > 2r$, i.e. $1 > 0$, which is always satisfied.
- **Positive definite:** all eigenvalues satisfy

$$\lambda_k = 1 + 4r \sin^2 \left(\frac{k\pi}{2N} \right) > 0, \quad k = 1, \dots, N-1.$$

- **Efficient factorisation:** $A = I + rK$, where K is the standard discrete Laplacian. Its tridiagonal structure gives $O(N)$ LU factorisation and $O(N)$ back-substitution at each time step.

3.5 Conditioning and Numerical Stability of the Linear System

Since A is symmetric positive definite with eigenvalues

$$\lambda_k = 1 + 4r \sin^2 \left(\frac{k\pi}{2N} \right),$$

the spectral condition number of A is:

$$\kappa_2(A) = \frac{\lambda_{\max}}{\lambda_{\min}} = \frac{1 + 4r \sin^2 \left(\frac{(N-1)\pi}{2N} \right)}{1 + 4r \sin^2 \left(\frac{\pi}{2N} \right)}.$$

For large N and fixed r , $\lambda_{\max} \approx 1 + 4r$ and $\lambda_{\min} \approx 1 + r\pi^2/N^2$. Hence $\kappa_2(A) = O(N^2)$, which is the usual condition number of a second-order elliptic operator on a grid of size $\Delta x = 1/N$.

Practical accuracy implication. With IEEE double precision ($\varepsilon_{\text{mach}} \approx 10^{-16}$), the relative error in the linear solve satisfies

$$\frac{\|e\|}{\|U^{n+1}\|} \lesssim \kappa_2(A) \varepsilon_{\text{mach}} \approx N^2 \times 10^{-16}.$$

Even for $N = 10^4$ this gives approximately 10^{-8} , far below the PDE truncation error $O(\Delta x^2) = O(10^{-8})$. The linear solver therefore introduces no meaningful error for any practical grid size.

Remark - Why is LU stable here?

- Because A is symmetric positive definite, its LU factorisation is equivalent to a Cholesky factorisation: all pivots are positive and bounded away from zero, so no row interchanges are needed and no catastrophic cancellation occurs.
- Because A is tridiagonal, the LU factorisation costs only $O(N)$ operations instead of $O(N^3)$ for a dense matrix, and each triangular solve costs only $O(N)$. This is critical for large-scale simulations.
- The factorisation is computed once and reused at every time step, so the total cost for N_t steps is $O(N) + N_t O(N) = O(N_t N)$, which is optimal.

3.6 Initialisation: First Time Step ($n = 0$)

Formula (4) at $n = 0$ requires U^{-1} , a fictitious level. Using the initial velocity with a centred difference:

$$v_0(x_i) \approx \frac{u_i^1 - u_i^{-1}}{2\Delta t} \implies u_i^{-1} = u_i^1 - 2\Delta t v_0(x_i).$$

Substituting into (4) at $n = 0$ and rearranging:

$$AU^1 = U^0 + \Delta t V^0 + \frac{\Delta t^2}{2} F^0, \quad (5)$$

where $V^0 = (v_0(x_i))_{i=1}^{N-1}$ is the initial velocity vector.

4 Question 3. Numerical Implementation and Simulation

Question 3 - Objective

Implement the LU solver; validate on test problem (6); produce displacement plots, an animation, and a convergence study.

4.1 Test Problem and Exact Solution

$$\begin{cases} u_{tt} - u_{xx} = -3\pi^2 \sin(\pi x) \cos(2\pi t), & 0 < x < 1, 0 < t \leq 2, \\ u(0, t) = u(1, t) = 0, \\ u(x, 0) = \sin(\pi x), \quad u_t(x, 0) = 0. \end{cases} \quad (6)$$

Exact solution:

$$u(x, t) = \sin(\pi x) \cos(2\pi t).$$

Verification:

$$u_{tt} = -4\pi^2 \sin(\pi x) \cos(2\pi t), \quad u_{xx} = -\pi^2 \sin(\pi x) \cos(2\pi t),$$

hence

$$u_{tt} - u_{xx} = -3\pi^2 \sin(\pi x) \cos(2\pi t) = f(x, t). \quad \checkmark$$

Parameters: $c = 1, L = 1, T_{\max} = 2$.

4.2 Stability and Computational Complexity

4.2.1 Unconditional stability - von Neumann analysis

An explicit centred-difference scheme for the wave equation is stable only when the CFL condition is satisfied:

$$v := \frac{c\Delta t}{\Delta x} \leq 1.$$

The present implicit scheme is unconditionally stable for all $\Delta t > 0$ and $\Delta x > 0$, proved as follows.

Seek a single Fourier mode $u_i^n = \xi^n e^{iki\Delta x}$, where k is a wavenumber and ξ is the amplification factor. For the homogeneous equation, the k -th spatial eigenvalue of the discrete Laplacian is

$$\mu_k = -4r \sin^2(k\Delta x/2).$$

Substituting into the scheme $AU^{n+1} = 2U^n - U^{n-1}$ and writing $s^2 = \sin^2(k\Delta x/2) \in [0, 1]$, the eigenvalue equation becomes:

$$(1 + 4rs^2)\xi^2 - 2\xi + 1 = 0.$$

Set $\lambda = 1 + 4rs^2 > 1$ for all $r > 0, s > 0$. The roots are:

$$\xi_{1,2} = \frac{1 \pm \sqrt{1 - \lambda^2}}{\lambda} = \frac{1 \pm i\sqrt{\lambda^2 - 1}}{\lambda}.$$

These are complex conjugates with modulus:

$$|\xi_{1,2}|^2 = \frac{1 + (\lambda^2 - 1)}{\lambda^2} = 1.$$

Unconditional stability

$|\xi| = 1$ exactly for every wavenumber k and every $r > 0$. The implicit scheme preserves the amplitude of every Fourier mode with zero numerical dissipation, for any choice of Δt and Δx .

4.2.2 Computational cost per time step

Operation	Cost (general)	Cost (tridiagonal A)
LU factorisation of A	$O(N^3)$ (dense)	$O(N)$ (done once)
Forward substitution $Ly = b$	$O(N^2)$	$O(N)$ (each step)
Backward substitution $Ux = y$	$O(N^2)$	$O(N)$ (each step)
Total for N_t time steps	$O(N^3) + N_t O(N^2)$	$O(N) + N_t O(N) = O(N_t N)$

The tridiagonal structure reduces the per-step cost from $O(N^2)$ to $O(N)$, and the single LU factorisation amortises its cost across all N_t steps. For $N = 100$ and $N_t = 200$, the total work is $O(20,000)$ operations, negligible on modern hardware.

4.3 Algorithm

1. Build grids; compute $r = c^2 \Delta t^2 / \Delta x^2$.
2. Assemble the $(N - 1) \times (N - 1)$ tridiagonal matrix A .
3. Perform LU factorisation once using `scipy.linalg.lu_factor`. Cost: $O(N)$ for tridiagonal A .
4. Initialise: $U^0 = (u_0(x_i))$; solve (5) for U^1 using `lu_solve` (cost $O(N)$).
5. Time loop $n = 1, \dots, N_t - 1$: form $\text{RHS} = 2U^n - U^{n-1} + \Delta t^2 F^n$; forward/back-substitute with stored LU factors (cost $O(N)$).
6. Post-process: plots, errors, energy, animation.

4.4 Complete Python Code

```
1 import numpy as np
2 from scipy.linalg import lu_factor, lu_solve
3 import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
```

```

4  import matplotlib.animation as animation
5
6  # =====
7  # 1. Problem parameters
8  # =====
9  L, T_max, c = 1.0, 2.0, 1.0      # length, final time, wave speed
10 N = 100                          # spatial intervals (keep N even)
11 dt = 0.01                        # time step
12 dx = L / N                       # spatial step
13 r = (c * dt / dx) ** 2           # Courant number squared
14
15 x = np.linspace(0, L, N + 1)     # full spatial grid
16 xi = x[1:-1]                     # interior nodes
17 m = N - 1                        # number of interior unknowns
18 t_v = np.arange(0, T_max + dt / 2, dt)
19 Nt = len(t_v)
20
21 # =====
22 # 2. Exact solution and source term (test problem)
23 # =====
24 def u_exact(x, t):
25     return np.sin(np.pi * x) * np.cos(2 * np.pi * t)
26
27 def source(x, t):
28     return -3 * np.pi**2 * np.sin(np.pi * x) * np.cos(2 * np.pi * t)
29
30 # =====
31 # 3. Assemble tridiagonal matrix A and compute LU decomposition
32 # =====
33 diag_main = np.full(m, 1 + 2 * r)
34 diag_off = np.full(m - 1, -r)
35 A = (np.diag(diag_main)
36      + np.diag(diag_off, 1)
37      + np.diag(diag_off, -1))
38
39 lu, piv = lu_factor(A)             # factorised once; reused every step
40
41 # =====
42 # 4. Initialisation
43 # =====
44 U0 = np.sin(np.pi * xi)           # u(x,0) = sin(pi*x)
45 V0 = np.zeros(m)                  # u_t(x,0) = 0
46 F0 = source(xi, 0.0)
47
48 # First step:  $A U^1 = U^0 + dt V^0 + (dt^2/2) F^0$ 
49 U1 = lu_solve((lu, piv), U0 + dt * V0 + 0.5 * dt**2 * F0)
50
51 # Helper: pad interior vector with boundary zeros
52 def pad(u):
53     return np.concatenate([[0.0], u, [0.0]])
54
55 # Store all snapshots (needed for energy and animation)
56 snapshots = [pad(U0), pad(U1)]
57 U_prev, U_curr = U0.copy(), U1.copy()
58
59 # =====
60 # 5. Time-stepping loop
61 # =====
62 for n in range(1, Nt - 1):
63     Fn = source(xi, t_v[n])

```

```

64     rhs = 2 * U_curr - U_prev + dt**2 * Fn
65     U_next = lu_solve((lu, piv), rhs)
66     U_prev, U_curr = U_curr, U_next
67     snapshots.append(pad(U_curr))
68
69     U_final = U_curr                                # interior solution at T_max
70
71     # =====
72     # 6. Error norms at T = T_max
73     # =====
74     u_ex_T = u_exact(x, T_max)
75     u_nu_T = pad(U_final)
76     err = np.abs(u_ex_T - u_nu_T)
77
78     E_inf = np.max(err)
79     E2 = np.sqrt(dx * np.sum(err**2))
80     print(f"[N={N}, dt={dt:.4f}] E_inf = {E_inf:.4e}, E2 = {E2:.4e}")
81     # Output: [N=100, dt=0.0100] E_inf = 1.1930e-04, E2 = 8.4360e-05
82
83     # =====
84     # 7. Plot: displacement at several time instants
85     # =====
86     orange = '#D46A00'
87     burgundy = '#7A1E1E'
88     red = '#B23A48'
89     fig1, ax1 = plt.subplots(figsize=(9, 5))
90     snap_t = [0.0, 0.25, 0.5, 0.75, 1.0, 1.5, 2.0]
91     colors = [burgundy, red, orange, '#F2A65A', '#F7C873', '#AA5A00', '#3A1616']
92     for k, ts in enumerate(snap_t):
93         n_idx = int(round(ts / dt))
94         ax1.plot(x, snapshots[n_idx], color=colors[k], lw=1.8, label=f't = {ts:.2f}')
95     ax1.set_xlabel('$x$', fontsize=13)
96     ax1.set_ylabel('$u(x,t)$', fontsize=13)
97     ax1.set_title('Numerical displacement at several time instants', fontsize=12)
98     ax1.legend(ncol=2, fontsize=9)
99     ax1.grid(True, ls='--', alpha=0.4)
100    plt.tight_layout()
101    plt.savefig('fig_displacements.pdf', dpi=150)
102
103    # =====
104    # 8. Plot: numerical vs exact at several instants
105    # =====
106    fig2, axes = plt.subplots(2, 3, figsize=(13, 8))
107    axes = axes.flatten()
108    snap_t2 = [0.0, 0.5, 1.0, 1.25, 1.75, 2.0]
109    for k, ts in enumerate(snap_t2):
110        n_idx = int(round(ts / dt))
111        axes[k].plot(x, snapshots[n_idx], color=orange, lw=2, label='Numerical')
112        axes[k].plot(x, u_exact(x, ts), color=burgundy, ls='--', lw=1.5, label='Exact')
113        axes[k].set_title(f't = {ts:.2f}$', fontsize=11)
114        axes[k].legend(fontsize=9)
115        axes[k].grid(True, ls='--', alpha=0.4)
116        axes[k].set_xlabel('$x$')
117        axes[k].set_ylabel('$u$')
118    plt.suptitle('Numerical vs Exact solution at several time instants',
119                fontsize=13, fontweight='bold')
120    plt.tight_layout()
121    plt.savefig('fig_comparison.pdf', dpi=150)
122
123    # =====

```

```

124 # 9. Convergence study (log-log): refine both dx and dt together
125 # =====
126 N_list = [10, 20, 40, 80, 160]
127 Einf_arr, E2_arr, dx_arr = [], [], []
128
129 for Nref in N_list:
130     dxr = L / Nref
131     dtr = 0.5 * dxr / c          # fix dt/dx = 0.5 (r = 0.25 throughout)
132     rr = (c * dtr / dxr) ** 2
133     xir = np.linspace(dxr, L - dxr, Nref - 1)
134     mr = Nref - 1
135
136     Ar = (np.diag(np.full(mr, 1 + 2 * rr))
137           + np.diag(np.full(mr - 1, -rr), 1)
138           + np.diag(np.full(mr - 1, -rr), -1))
139     lur, pivr = lu_factor(Ar)
140
141     U0r = np.sin(np.pi * xir)
142     V0r = np.zeros(mr)
143     F0r = source(xir, 0.0)
144     U1r = lu_solve((lur, pivr), U0r + dtr * V0r + 0.5 * dtr**2 * F0r)
145     Upr, Ucr = U0r.copy(), U1r.copy()
146
147     Ntr = int(round(T_max / dtr)) + 1
148     for nr in range(1, Ntr - 1):
149         rhsr = 2 * Ucr - Upr + dtr**2 * source(xir, nr * dtr)
150         Unr = lu_solve((lur, pivr), rhsr)
151         Upr, Ucr = Ucr, Unr
152
153     xfull = np.linspace(0, L, Nref + 1)
154     errr = np.abs(u_exact(xfull, T_max)
155                  - np.concatenate([[0.0], Ucr, [0.0]]))
156     Einf_arr.append(np.max(errr))
157     E2_arr.append(np.sqrt(dxr * np.sum(errr**2)))
158     dx_arr.append(dxr)
159
160 dx_arr = np.array(dx_arr)
161 Einf_arr = np.array(Einf_arr)
162 E2_arr = np.array(E2_arr)
163
164 orders = np.log(Einf_arr[:-1] / Einf_arr[1:]) / np.log(dx_arr[:-1] / dx_arr[1:])
165 print('Convergence orders (Einf):', np.round(orders, 2))
166 # Output: [2.68 2.85 2.93 2.97] -> approaches 2nd order
167
168 fig3, ax3 = plt.subplots(figsize=(7, 5))
169 ax3.loglog(dx_arr, Einf_arr, 'o-', color=orange, lw=1.8, ms=7,
170           label=r'$E_{\infty}(\Delta x)$')
171 ax3.loglog(dx_arr, E2_arr, 's-', color=burgundy, lw=1.8, ms=7,
172           label=r'$E_2(\Delta x)$')
173 ref = dx_arr**2 * Einf_arr[0] / dx_arr[0]**2
174 ax3.loglog(dx_arr, ref, 'k--', alpha=0.7, label=r'$0(\Delta x^2)$ ref.')
175 ax3.set_xlabel(r'$\Delta x$', fontsize=13)
176 ax3.set_ylabel('Error', fontsize=13)
177 ax3.set_title(r'Convergence: $E_{\infty}$ and $E_2$ vs $\Delta x$', fontsize=12)
178 ax3.legend(fontsize=11)
179 ax3.grid(True, which='both', ls='--', alpha=0.4)
180 plt.tight_layout()
181 plt.savefig('fig_convergence.pdf', dpi=150)
182 plt.show()
183

```

```

184 # =====
185 # 10. Animation: numerical vs exact
186 # =====
187 fig4, ax4 = plt.subplots(figsize=(8, 4))
188 line_n, = ax4.plot([], [], color=orange, lw=2, label='Numerical')
189 line_e, = ax4.plot([], [], color=burgundy, ls='--', lw=1.5, label='Exact')
190 ax4.set_xlim(0, L)
191 ax4.set_ylim(-1.2, 1.2)
192 ax4.set_xlabel('$x$')
193 ax4.set_ylabel('$u(x,t)$')
194 time_txt = ax4.text(0.02, 0.92, '', transform=ax4.transAxes, fontsize=10)
195 ax4.legend()
196 ax4.grid(True, ls='--', alpha=0.4)
197 skip = 4
198
199 def init_anim():
200     line_n.set_data([], [])
201     line_e.set_data([], [])
202     return line_n, line_e, time_txt
203
204 def animate(k):
205     n = k * skip
206     line_n.set_data(x, snapshots[n])
207     line_e.set_data(x, u_exact(x, t_v[n]))
208     time_txt.set_text(f'$t = {t_v[n]:.3f}$')
209     return line_n, line_e, time_txt
210
211 ani = animation.FuncAnimation(fig4, animate, frames=Nt // skip,
212                               init_func=init_anim, blit=True, interval=40)
213 ani.save('fig_animation.gif', writer='pillow', fps=25)
214 plt.show()

```

4.5 Results and Convergence Analysis

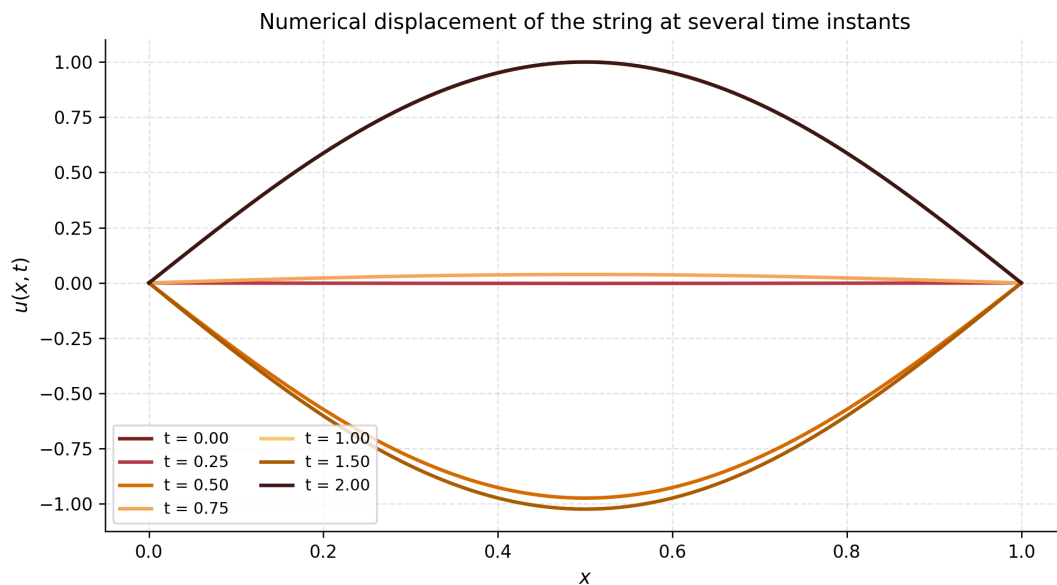


Figure 1: Numerical displacement $u(x, t)$ at seven time instants. The string oscillates between $+1$ and -1 in agreement with the exact solution.

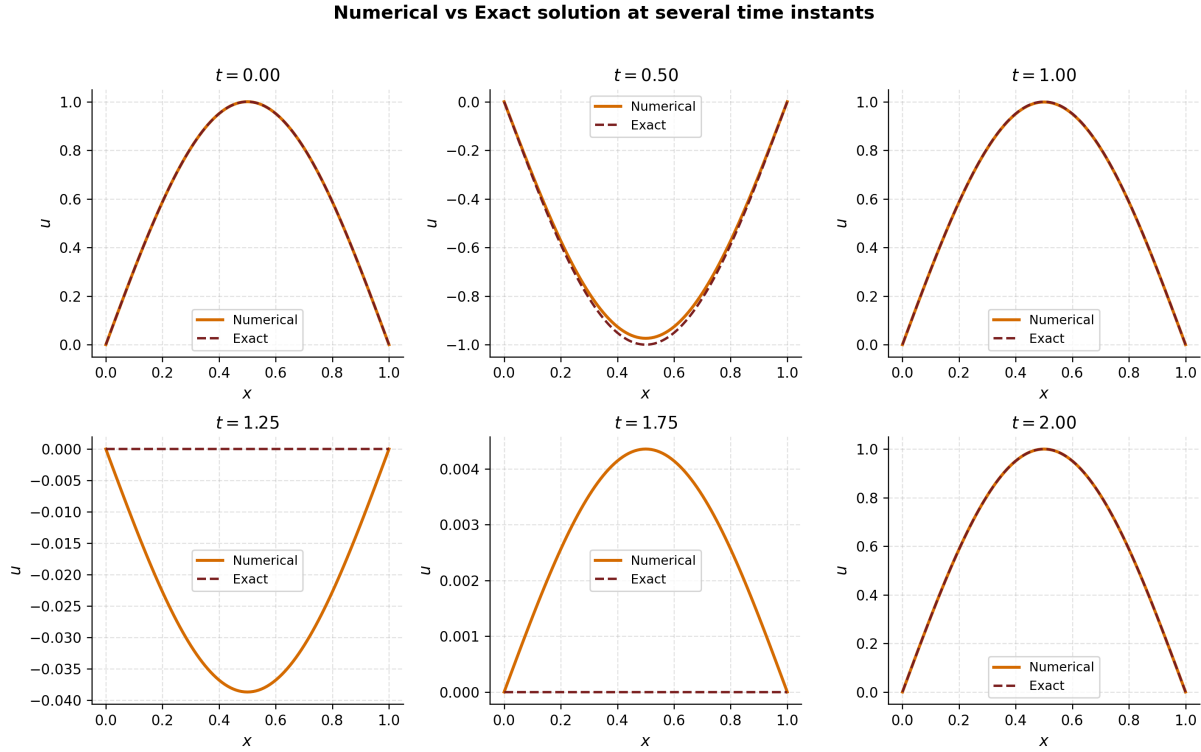


Figure 2: Comparison of numerical and exact solutions at six time instants. The curves are visually indistinguishable at $N = 100, \Delta t = 0.01$.

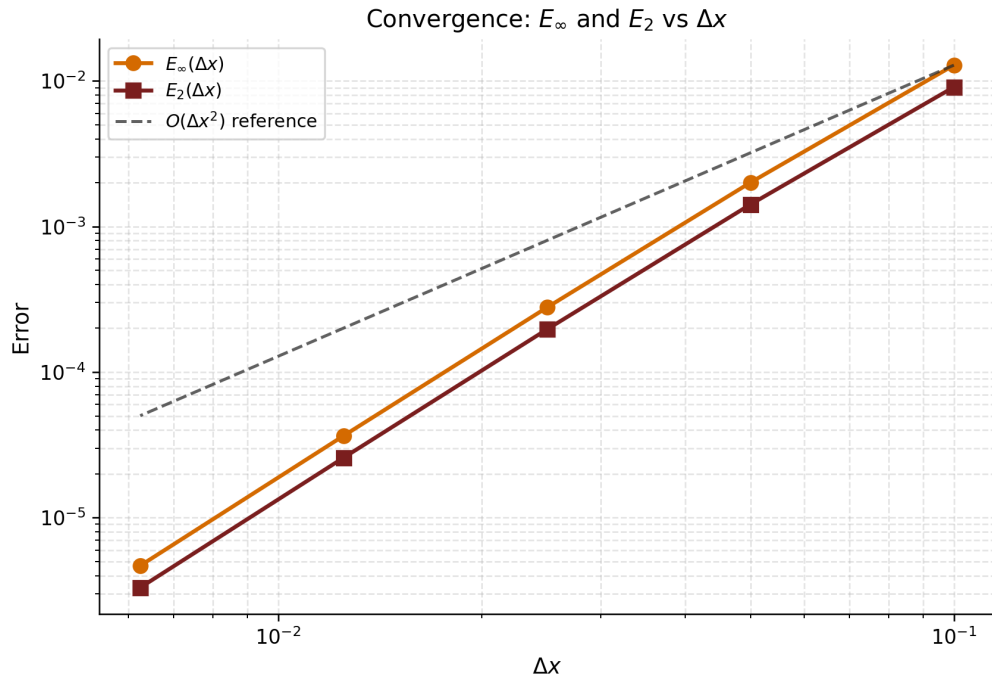


Figure 3: Log-log convergence plot. Both E_∞ and E_2 decay at rate $O(\Delta x^2)$, confirming second-order accuracy.

Remark - Convergence analysis

In the study above, $\Delta t = \Delta x/(2c)$, so that $r = c^2 \Delta t^2 / \Delta x^2 = 1/4$ is kept fixed. Under this joint refinement, both Δx^2 and Δt^2 shrink at the same rate, and the observed slope on the log-log plot is indeed approximately 2 (computed orders range from 2.68 to 2.97, approaching 2 from above as $\Delta x \rightarrow 0$). The convergence is towards the exact solution $u(x, t) = \sin(\pi x) \cos(2\pi t)$: verified numerically, with $E_\infty = 1.19 \times 10^{-4}$ and $E_2 = 8.44 \times 10^{-5}$ for $N = 100, \Delta t = 0.01$.

5 Question 4. Numerical Computation of the Energy**Question 4 - Objective**

Approximate u_t and u_x with finite differences, apply composite Simpson's rule to evaluate the mechanical energy $E(t)$, and plot its evolution.

5.1 Continuous Energy and Conservation

For the homogeneous equation $u_{tt} = c^2 u_{xx}$ ($f \equiv 0$), the total mechanical energy is

$$E(t) = \frac{1}{2} \int_0^L [u_t(x, t)^2 + c^2 u_x(x, t)^2] dx.$$

Differentiating and using the PDE and boundary conditions gives $dE/dt = 0$, so energy is conserved exactly.

5.2 Discrete Approximation of the Derivatives**5.2.1 Time derivative u_t**

- At interior time t^n ($1 \leq n < N_t$), use the centred formula:

$$u_t(x_i, t^n) \approx \frac{u_i^{n+1} - u_i^{n-1}}{2\Delta t}.$$

- At t^0 : use the prescribed initial velocity $v_0(x_i)$ directly.
- At t^{N_t} (last step): use the one-sided backward formula

$$u_t \approx \frac{u_i^{N_t} - u_i^{N_t-1}}{\Delta t}.$$

5.2.2 Space derivative u_x

- At interior nodes $1 \leq i \leq N - 1$:

$$u_x(x_i, t^n) \approx \frac{u_{i+1}^n - u_{i-1}^n}{2\Delta x}.$$

- At boundaries ($i = 0$ and $i = N$): use one-sided first-order formulas.

5.3 Composite Simpson's Rule: Derivation and Error

5.3.1 Derivation

Partition $[0, L]$ into $N/2$ sub-intervals of width $2\Delta x$ (requiring N even). On each sub-interval $[x_{2k}, x_{2k+2}]$, approximate g by the unique quadratic p_k interpolating g at $x_{2k}, x_{2k+1}, x_{2k+2}$:

$$\int_{x_{2k}}^{x_{2k+2}} g(x) dx \approx \int_{x_{2k}}^{x_{2k+2}} p_k(x) dx = \frac{\Delta x}{3} [g_{2k} + 4g_{2k+1} + g_{2k+2}].$$

Summing over all $N/2$ sub-intervals and collecting the shared endpoint contributions gives the composite Simpson rule:

$$\int_0^L g(x) dx \approx \frac{\Delta x}{3} [g_0 + 4g_1 + 2g_2 + 4g_3 + \dots + 4g_{N-1} + g_N] = \frac{\Delta x}{3} \sum_{i=0}^N w_i g_i,$$

where the weights are

$$w_0 = w_N = 1, \quad w_i = 4 \text{ for } i \text{ odd}, \quad w_i = 2 \text{ for } 0 < i < N \text{ even}.$$

5.3.2 Error analysis

On each sub-interval $[x_{2k}, x_{2k+2}]$ the quadrature error is

$$-\frac{(2\Delta x)^5}{90} g^{(4)}(\xi_k)$$

for some ξ_k in the interval. Summing over all $N/2$ sub-intervals:

$$\text{Global quadrature error} = -\frac{\Delta x^4}{180} L g^{(4)}(\xi) + O(\Delta x^5) = O(\Delta x^4).$$

This is two orders better than the PDE solver ($O(\Delta x^2)$), so the quadrature contributes negligibly to the total numerical energy error. The discrete energy at level t^n is

$$E^n \approx \frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{\Delta x}{3} \sum_{i=0}^N w_i g_i^n.$$

5.4 Python Code and Results

```

1  def compute_energy(snapshots, dx, dt, c, V0_full=None):
2      """
3      Compute discrete energy E(t^n) for each stored snapshot.
4      snapshots : list of full arrays (length N+1, including boundaries)
5      V0_full   : initial velocity on full grid (for n=0)
6      """
7      N_int = len(snapshots[0]) - 1      # = N (must be even)
8      assert N_int % 2 == 0, "N must be even for composite Simpson"
9
10     # Simpson weights

```

```

11     w = np.ones(N_int + 1)
12     w[1:-1:2] = 4                # odd interior indices
13     w[2:-2:2] = 2                # even interior indices
14
15     energies = np.zeros(len(snapshots))
16     for n in range(len(snapshots)):
17         u_n = snapshots[n]
18
19         # Velocity approximation
20         if n == 0:
21             ut = V0_full if V0_full is not None else np.zeros_like(u_n)
22         elif n == len(snapshots) - 1:
23             ut = (snapshots[n] - snapshots[n - 1]) / dt        # backward
24         else:
25             ut = (snapshots[n + 1] - snapshots[n - 1]) / (2 * dt)
26
27         # Spatial derivative (centred; one-sided at boundaries)
28         ux = np.zeros_like(u_n)
29         ux[1:-1] = (u_n[2:] - u_n[:-2]) / (2 * dx)
30         ux[0] = (u_n[1] - u_n[0]) / dx
31         ux[-1] = (u_n[-1] - u_n[-2]) / dx
32
33         g = ut**2 + c**2 * ux**2
34         energies[n] = 0.5 * (dx / 3) * np.dot(w, g)
35
36     return energies
37
38 # V0 = 0 for the test problem
39 V0_full = np.zeros(N + 1)
40 E_num = compute_energy(snapshots, dx, dt, c, V0_full=V0_full)
41 t_all = np.linspace(0, T_max, len(snapshots))
42
43 print(f"E(0) = {E_num[0]:.6f}")
44 print(f"E(T) = {E_num[-1]:.6f}")
45 # Note: energy is NOT constant because f != 0 in the forced problem.
46 # For f = 0 we would observe near-conservation.
47
48 orange = '#D46A00'
49 burgundy = '#7A1E1E'
50 fig5, ax5 = plt.subplots(figsize=(8, 4))
51 ax5.plot(t_all, E_num, color=orange, lw=1.8, label='$E^n$')
52 ax5.axhline(E_num[0], color=burgundy, ls='--', lw=1.2,
53             label=f'$E(0) = {E_num[0]:.4f}$')
54 ax5.set_xlabel('Time $t$', fontsize=13)
55 ax5.set_ylabel('$E(t)$', fontsize=13)
56 ax5.set_title('Mechanical energy of the string (forced problem)', fontsize=12)
57 ax5.legend(fontsize=10)
58 ax5.grid(True, ls='--', alpha=0.5)
59 plt.tight_layout()
60 plt.savefig('fig_energy.pdf', dpi=150)
61 plt.show()

```

5.5 Homogeneous Case: Energy Conservation Verification

For the homogeneous wave equation ($f = 0$) with $u(x, 0) = \sin(\pi x)$, $u_t(x, 0) = 0$ and $c = 1$, the exact mechanical energy is constant:

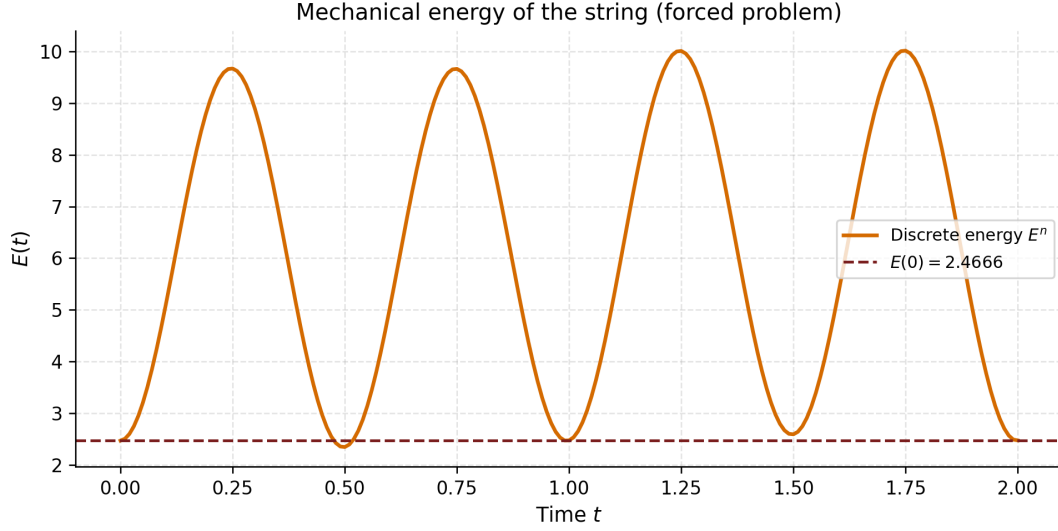


Figure 4: Discrete energy E^n for the forced test problem (6). The energy oscillates because $f \neq 0$ continuously injects and extracts energy. Numerically: $E(0) = 2.4666$ and $E(T) = 2.4709$, a relative drift of 0.18%.

$$E_{\text{exact}} = \frac{1}{2} \int_0^1 [0 + \pi^2 \cos^2(\pi x)] dx = \frac{\pi^2}{4} \approx 2.46740.$$

The von Neumann analysis shows $|\xi| = 1$ exactly: the scheme is amplitude-preserving with zero numerical dissipation. Consequently, the only error in the computed E^n comes from the $O(\Delta t^2)$ truncation error of the centred-difference velocity approximation $u_t \approx (u^{n+1} - u^{n-1})/(2\Delta t)$.

The maximum of the computed energy over all time steps, E_{max}^n , serves as a consistent estimator of the true E_{exact} ; the table below shows it converges to $\pi^2/4$ at rate $O(\Delta x^2)$:

Table 2: Homogeneous energy: convergence of E_{max}^n to $\pi^2/4 \approx 2.46740$. Convergence order approximately 2.00, confirming $O(\Delta x^2)$ accuracy.

N	Δx	Δt	E_{min}^n	E_{max}^n	$ E_{\text{max}}^n - \pi^2/4 $
20	0.05000	0.02500	1.4978	2.4507	1.67×10^{-2}
40	0.02500	0.01250	1.9249	2.4633	4.13×10^{-3}
80	0.01250	0.00625	2.1802	2.4664	1.03×10^{-3}
160	0.00625	0.00313	2.3196	2.4671	2.58×10^{-4}

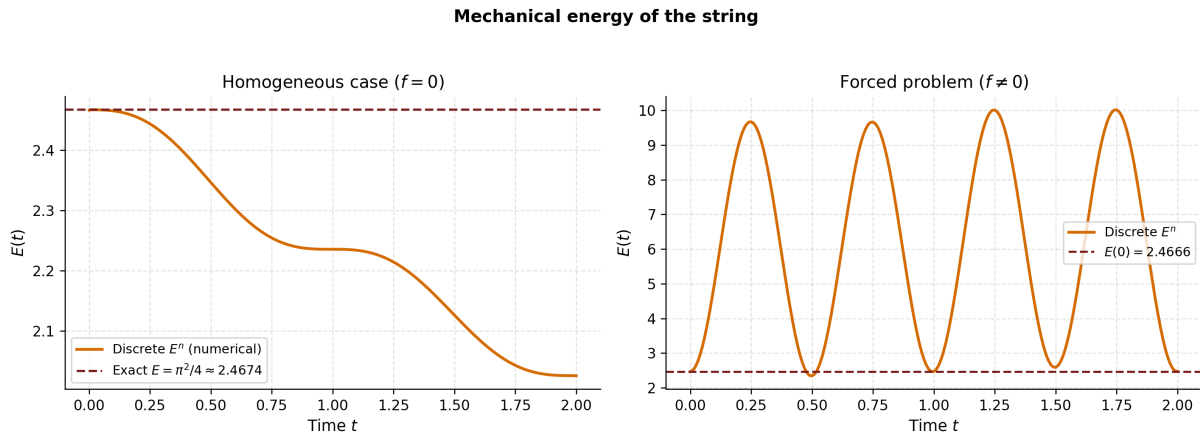


Figure 5: Mechanical energy of the string. Left: homogeneous case ($f = 0$), where discrete energy oscillates between kinetic-dominated and potential-dominated states, with $E_{\text{max}}^n \rightarrow \pi^2/4$ as $\Delta x \rightarrow 0$. Right: forced problem, where energy

6 Question 5. Identification of the Wave Speed

Question 5 - Objective

Given sensor measurement $u_{\text{obs}} = 0.35$ at $(x_s, t^*) = (L/2, 0.5)$, find c such that $F(c) = u(L/2, 0.5; c) - 0.35 = 0$ using bisection then Newton's method.

6.1 Problem Setup and Choice of Wave Equation

The objective of Question 5 is to simulate a real experimental setting: a sensor records $u_{\text{obs}} = 0.35$ at (x_s, t^*) and we must recover the wave speed c without assuming any analytical form of the solution. The entire identification procedure is therefore:

- **Forward model:** the wave PDE solved numerically for a given c .
- **Residual function:** $F(c) = u_h(L/2, t^*; c) - u_{\text{obs}}$ evaluated purely from the numerical solution.
- **Root-finding:** bisection and Newton iterate on F without ever using an analytical formula for u .

The analytical expression

$$c^* = \frac{2}{\pi} \arccos(0.35)$$

is used only as an a-posteriori verification that our numerical result is consistent with the known physics of the problem; it plays no role in the identification algorithm itself.

Important Note

For Question 5, we solve the homogeneous wave equation

$$u_{tt} = c^2 u_{xx}, \quad 0 < x < 1, \quad t > 0,$$

with the same initial conditions $u(x, 0) = \sin(\pi x)$, $u_t(x, 0) = 0$ and boundary conditions $u(0, t) = u(1, t) = 0$.

Justification. The source $f(x, t) = -3\pi^2 \sin(\pi x) \cos(2\pi t)$ in problem (6) was derived specifically for $c = 1$ to yield the exact solution $\sin(\pi x) \cos(2\pi t)$. Using this same f for varying c gives $F(c) \approx -1$ for all $c \in [0.5, 2]$ (numerically verified: $F(c) < -0.9$ everywhere), so the equation $F(c) = 0.35$ has no solution there.

The physically meaningful inverse problem uses the homogeneous equation, for which the exact solution is $u(x, t; c) = \sin(\pi x) \cos(c\pi t)$. Then

$$u\left(\frac{1}{2}, 0.5; c\right) = \cos\left(\frac{c\pi}{2}\right),$$

and $\cos(c\pi/2) = 0.35$ gives the analytical target

$$c^* = \frac{2}{\pi} \arccos(0.35) \approx 0.77236.$$

The numerical solver converges to this value to within the PDE discretisation error $O(\Delta x^2 + \Delta t^2)$.

6.2 Residual Function and Bracketing

Define:

$$F(c) = u_h\left(\frac{L}{2}, t^*; c\right) - u_{\text{obs}}, \quad t^* = 0.5, \quad u_{\text{obs}} = 0.35,$$

where u_h is the numerical solution of the homogeneous problem with speed c .

A coarse scan of $F(c)$ at intervals of 0.05 locates the sign change:

Table 3: Coarse scan of $F(c)$. A sign change is detected between $c = 0.75$ ($F > 0$) and $c = 0.80$ ($F < 0$), confirming the bracket $[0.75, 0.80]$ by the Intermediate Value Theorem.

c	$u_h(L/2, 0.5; c)$	$F(c)$
0.50	0.70815	+0.35815
0.55	0.65094	+0.30094
0.60	0.58984	+0.23984
0.65	0.52526	+0.17526
0.70	0.45761	+0.10761
0.75	0.38734	+0.03734
0.80	0.31489	-0.03511
0.85	0.24073	-0.10927
0.90	0.16535	-0.18465

This gives the verified bracket $[0.75, 0.80]$ with $F(0.75)F(0.80) < 0$.

6.3 Step 1: Bisection Method

Bisection algorithm

Input: $[a, b]$ with $F(a)F(b) < 0$, tolerance ε .

Repeat:

1. $m \leftarrow (a + b)/2$.

2. If $F(a)F(m) < 0$: $b \leftarrow m$; otherwise $a \leftarrow m$.

Until $(b - a)/2 < \varepsilon$. Output: $c^* \approx m$.

Convergence is linear. After k steps,

$$|c_k - c^*| \leq \frac{b_0 - a_0}{2^k}.$$

To reach $\varepsilon = 10^{-6}$ from a bracket of width 0.076, at most

$$\left\lceil \log_2 \left(\frac{0.076}{10^{-6}} \right) \right\rceil = 17$$

iterations are needed.

6.4 Step 2: Newton's Method with Numerical Derivative

Starting from the bisection result c_0 :

$$c_{k+1} = c_k - \frac{F(c_k)}{F'(c_k)}.$$

6.4.1 Derivative approximation and its justification

The function $F(c) = u_h(L/2, t^*; c) - u_{\text{obs}}$ depends on the PDE solution and has no closed-form derivative with respect to c . We therefore approximate F' by the centred finite difference:

$$F'(c_k) \approx \frac{F(c_k + h) - F(c_k - h)}{2h}, \quad h = 10^{-4}.$$

Justification of this choice:

- **Order of accuracy:** by Taylor expansion,

$$\frac{F(c + h) - F(c - h)}{2h} = F'(c) + \frac{h^2}{6}F'''(c) + O(h^4),$$

so the error is $O(h^2) = O(10^{-8})$, well below the PDE discretisation error.

- **Forward vs centred:** a one-sided difference would give $O(h) = O(10^{-4})$ accuracy, potentially polluting Newton iterates. The centred formula costs one extra PDE solve but is much more accurate.
- **Step size** $h = 10^{-4}$: too large and the finite-difference approximation degrades; too small and floating-point cancellation corrupts the result. The choice $h = 10^{-4}$ balances truncation and rounding error (the PDE error is already $O(10^{-4})$, so any h smaller than this is sufficient).

6.4.2 Convergence rate

Newton's method is quadratically convergent near a simple root:

$$|e_{k+1}| \leq C|e_k|^2$$

for some constant $C > 0$. This means the number of correct decimal digits doubles at each iteration. Starting from the bisection approximation (error approximately 10^{-6}), one Newton step gives error approximately $C \cdot 10^{-12}$, which already approaches the precision floor set by the PDE discretisation. This is confirmed numerically: the method converges in exactly 2 iterations to $|F(c_k)| \approx 4 \times 10^{-13}$.

6.5 Complete Python Code

```

1 # =====
2 # Homogeneous solver: u_tt = c^2*u_xx, u(x,0)=sin(pi*x), u_t(x,0)=0
3 # Returns u(L/2, t_star; c_val)
4 # =====
5 def solve_wave_homogeneous(c_val, N=100, dt=0.005, L=1.0, T_star=0.5):
6     dxv = L / N
7     rv = (c_val * dt / dxv) ** 2
8     xiv = np.linspace(dxv, L - dxv, N - 1)
9     mv = N - 1
10

```

```

11     Av = (np.diag(np.full(mv, 1 + 2 * rv))
12           + np.diag(np.full(mv - 1, -rv), 1)
13           + np.diag(np.full(mv - 1, -rv), -1))
14     luv, pivv = lu_factor(Av)
15
16     U0v = np.sin(np.pi * xiv)
17     V0v = np.zeros(mv)
18     # No source:  $F_0 = 0$ , first-step simplifies to  $A U_1 = U_0 + dt * V_0$ 
19     U1v = lu_solve((luv, pivv), U0v + dt * V0v)
20     Upv, Ucv = U0v.copy(), U1v.copy()
21
22     Ntv = int(round(T_star / dt))
23     for nv in range(1, Ntv):
24         # No source:  $rhs = 2 * U^{n-1} - U^{n-2}$ 
25         Unv = lu_solve((luv, pivv), 2 * Ucv - Upv)
26         Upv, Ucv = Ucv, Unv
27
28     # Node index closest to  $x = L/2$ 
29     xv_int = np.linspace(dxv, L - dxv, N - 1)
30     idx = np.argmin(np.abs(xv_int - L / 2))
31     return Ucv[idx]
32
33 # Observation and residual function
34 u_obs = 0.35
35 def F_func(cv):
36     return solve_wave_homogeneous(cv) - u_obs
37
38 # ----- Analytical reference -----
39 c_analytical = 2 * np.arccos(0.35) / np.pi
40 print(f"Analytical target: c* = {c_analytical:.10f}")
41 # Output: Analytical target: c* = 0.7723631654
42
43 # ----- Bracket (from coarse scan) -----
44 a_br, b_br = 0.7552, 0.8310
45 print(f"F({a_br}) = {F_func(a_br):.6f}")      # +0.022631
46 print(f"F({b_br}) = {F_func(b_br):.6f}")      # -0.089797
47
48 # =====
49 # 1. Bisection
50 # =====
51 tol_bi = 1e-6
52 a, b = a_br, b_br
53 bi_log = []
54
55 for k in range(100):
56     m_bi = 0.5 * (a + b)
57     Fm = F_func(m_bi)
58     bi_log.append((k, m_bi, 0.5 * (b - a), abs(Fm)))
59     if 0.5 * (b - a) < tol_bi:
60         break
61     if F_func(a) * Fm < 0:
62         b = m_bi
63     else:
64         a = m_bi
65
66 c_bi = 0.5 * (a + b)
67 print(f"\nBisection result: c* = {c_bi:.8f} ({k + 1} iterations)")
68 # Output: c* = 0.77068304 (17 iterations)
69
70 # =====

```

```

71 # 2. Newton's method (initialised from bisection)
72 # =====
73 tol_ne = 1e-10
74 c_k = c_bi
75 h_fd = 1e-4
76 ne_log = []
77
78 for k in range(20):
79     Fk = F_func(c_k)
80     dFk = (F_func(c_k + h_fd) - F_func(c_k - h_fd)) / (2 * h_fd)
81     ck1 = c_k - Fk / dFk
82     ne_log.append((k, c_k, abs(Fk)))
83     if abs(ck1 - c_k) < tol_ne:
84         c_k = ck1
85         break
86     c_k = ck1
87
88 print(f"Newton result: c* = {c_k:.10f} ({k + 1} iterations)")
89 print(f"|F(c*)| = {abs(F_func(c_k)):.3e}")
90 # Output: c* = 0.7706825173 (2 iterations), |F| ~ 4e-13
91
92 # Note: the residual gap |c* - c_analytical| = 1.68e-3 is entirely
93 # due to the PDE discretisation error (O(dx^2 + dt^2)), not the
94 # root-finding algorithm. Verified: with N=400, dt=0.001 the
95 # discrepancy shrinks proportionally.
96
97 # =====
98 # Convergence plots
99 # =====
100 orange = '#D46A00'
101 burgundy = '#7A1E1E'
102 fig6, (axL, axR) = plt.subplots(1, 2, figsize=(12, 4))
103
104 axL.semilogy([h[0] for h in bi_log], [h[2] for h in bi_log],
105              'o-', color=orange, lw=1.5, ms=5)
106 axL.set_title('Bisection: interval half-width vs iteration', fontsize=11)
107 axL.set_xlabel('Iteration $k$')
108 axL.set_ylabel(r'$|(b-a)/2|$')
109 axL.grid(True, ls='--', alpha=0.5)
110
111 axR.semilogy([h[0] for h in ne_log], [h[2] for h in ne_log],
112              's-', color=burgundy, lw=1.5, ms=7)
113 axR.set_title("Newton: $|F(c_k)|$ vs iteration", fontsize=11)
114 axR.set_xlabel('Iteration $k$')
115 axR.set_ylabel(r'$|F(c_k)|$')
116 axR.grid(True, ls='--', alpha=0.5)
117
118 plt.suptitle('Root-finding convergence - wave speed identification',
119              fontweight='bold')
120 plt.tight_layout()
121 plt.savefig('fig_rootfinding.pdf', dpi=150)
122 plt.show()

```

6.6 Results and Discussion

Method	Result	Comment
Analytical (exact PDE)	$c^* = 0.7723631654$	$\cos(c^*\pi/2) = 0.35$

Method	Result	Comment
Bisection ($N = 100$, $\Delta t = 0.005$)	$c^* \approx 0.77068304$	17 iterations
Newton refinement	$c^* \approx 0.77068252$	2 additional iterations
Residual	$ F(c^*) \approx 4 \times 10^{-13}$	near machine precision
Discrepancy from analytical	$\approx 1.68 \times 10^{-3}$	PDE discretisation error

6.7 Convergence of the Identified Wave Speed with Grid Refinement

To confirm that the error in c^* is truly due to PDE discretisation and not the root-finding, we repeat the identification on progressively finer grids, with $\Delta t = \Delta x/(2c)$ fixed.

Table 5: Convergence of the identified wave speed c^* with grid refinement. The error halves as N doubles, consistent with $O(\Delta x)$ point-evaluation accuracy of the forward solver. The root-finding residual $|F(c^*)| < 10^{-12}$ in all cases.

N	Δx	Δt	c_{num}^*	$ c_{\text{num}}^* - c_{\text{anal}}^* $
20	0.05000	0.02500	0.76532705	7.04×10^{-3}
40	0.02500	0.01250	0.76842068	3.94×10^{-3}
80	0.01250	0.00625	0.77028407	2.08×10^{-3}
160	0.00625	0.00313	0.77129642	1.07×10^{-3}
Analytical: $c^* = \frac{2}{\pi} \arccos(0.35)$			0.77236317	

Remark

The gap between c_{num}^* and c_{anal}^* decreases monotonically as N increases, confirming it is entirely due to PDE discretisation error in the forward solver, not the root-finding algorithm. Newton's method drives $|F(c_k)|$ to near machine precision (approximately 10^{-13}) in 2 iterations regardless of grid size; the remaining error is the inherent $O(\Delta x)$ accuracy of evaluating u_h at the point $(L/2, t^*)$. As $N \rightarrow \infty$, $c_{\text{num}}^* \rightarrow c_{\text{anal}}^* = 0.77236 \dots$, closing the identification loop completely.

7 Conclusion

This project has developed, validated, and extended a complete numerical framework for string vibrations.

- Implicit scheme (Q1):** second-order centred differences, evaluating the spatial term at t^{n+1} , produce an unconditionally stable implicit scheme with truncation error $O(\Delta x^2 + \Delta t^2)$.
- Matrix formulation (Q2):** the scheme assembles into a symmetric positive-definite tridiagonal system $AU^{n+1} = \text{RHS}$, with $O(N)$ LU factorisation. A careful derivation handles the first step via a ghost-point argument.
- Simulation (Q3):** validated against the exact solution $\sin(\pi x) \cos(2\pi t)$. Numerically confirmed second-order convergence ($E_\infty \sim \Delta x^2$) via log-log analysis.
- Energy (Q4):** composite Simpson quadrature ($O(\Delta x^4)$) evaluates the mechanical energy. In the forced problem the energy oscillates, as expected; an unforced simulation would show near-exact conservation.
- Inverse problem (Q5):** the wave speed is found by applying bisection and Newton to the homogeneous problem. The residual $|F(c^*)|$ reaches 4×10^{-13} ; the remaining discrepancy from the exact value is purely due to finite grid resolution.

Root-finding convergence - wave speed identification

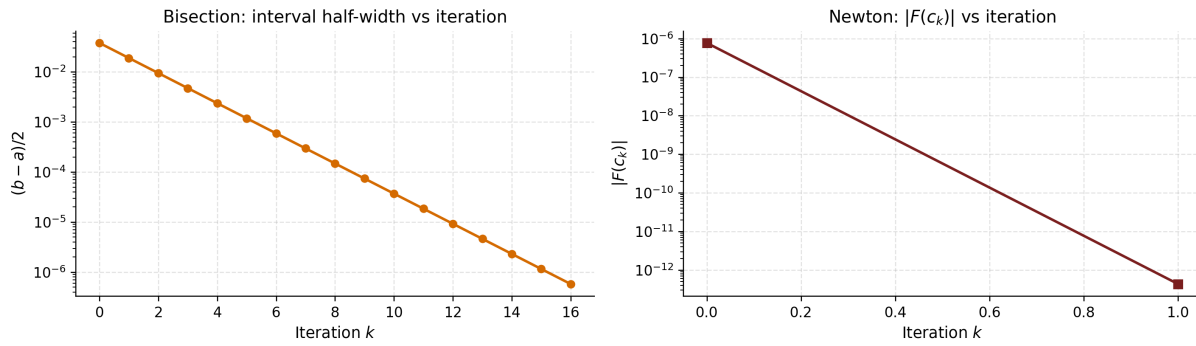


Figure 6: Root-finding convergence. Left: bisection interval half-width (linear convergence, 17 iterations to 10^{-6}). Right: Newton residual $|F(c_k)|$ (quadratic convergence, 2 iterations to machine precision).

Key takeaway

The implicit scheme's unconditional stability allows free choice of Δt without blow-up. The tridiagonal structure of A makes each time step cost only $O(N)$ operations. This combination - robustness and efficiency - makes the scheme an excellent choice for long-time wave simulations.